How to be happy 101





How to be happy 101



The science of well-being
@ Yale University Coursera

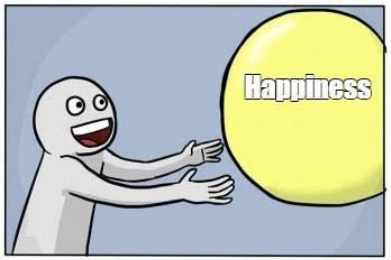


Book: A Guide to the Good Life:
The Ancient Art of Stoic Joy
by prof. of Philosophy W. Irvine @ WSU



Buddhism
(Additional & GPT-research)

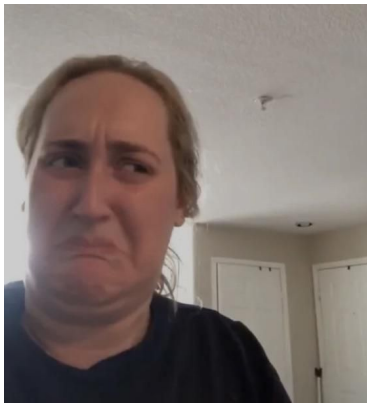
Disclaimer: Am I happy?



Disclaimer: Am I happy?



Meh…



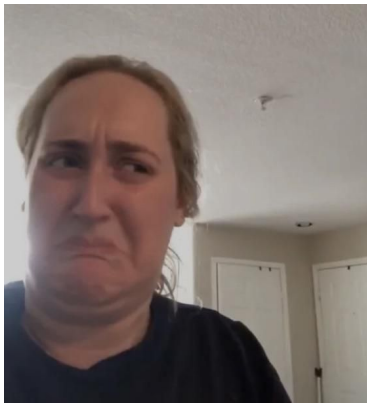
Disclaimer: Can **you** be happy?

Meh…



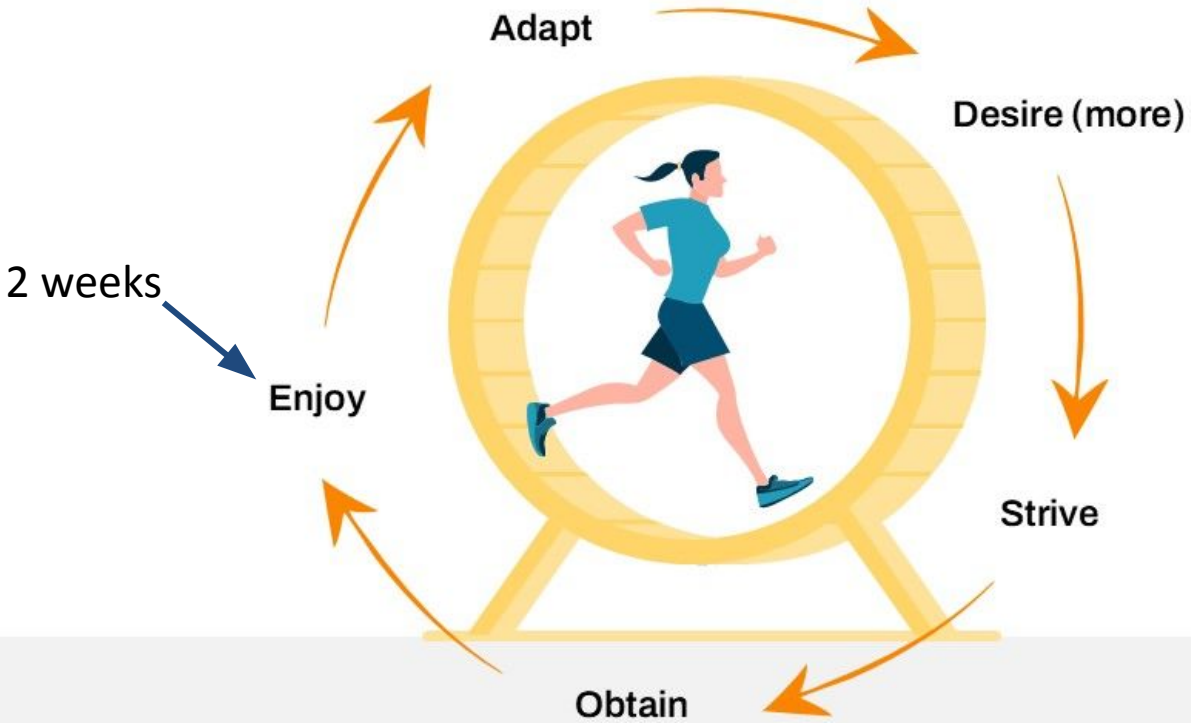
Disclaimer: Can **you** be happy?

Meh…
(Probably) no

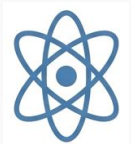




Why? Hedonic adaptation / treadmill



All 3 sources converge to this problem: <u>Hedonic Adaptation</u>



Science

YALE WELL-BEING COURSE

Brains misjudge lasting joy due to **Hedonic Adaptation** – rapidly adapting to life's updates.



Stoicism*

ANCIENT PHILOSOPHY

Warns against chasing status: we quickly adapt to wealth and constantly desire more.

* this is not asceticism



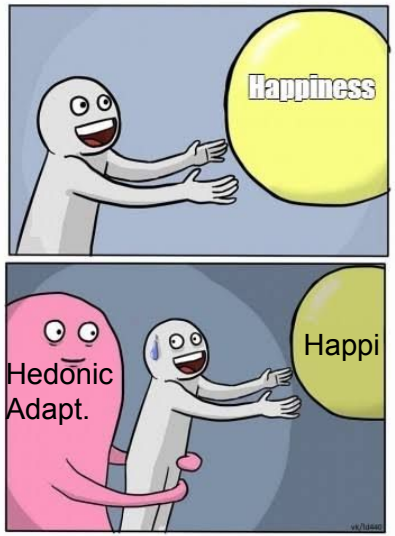
Buddhism

EASTERN TRADITION

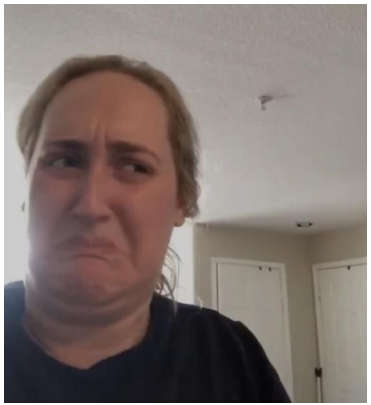
Craving (*Tanha*) and attachment to temporary pleasures cause perpetual dissatisfaction.

Core Shared Insight: The Treadmill of Desire is REAL

Can **you** be happy?



Meh…
(Probably) no???



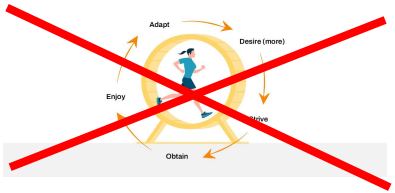


All 3 converge to 1 solution:
Amplify Joy and Appreciate what you have

- Remember/think of how bad it was previously

NEGATIVE VISUALIZATION

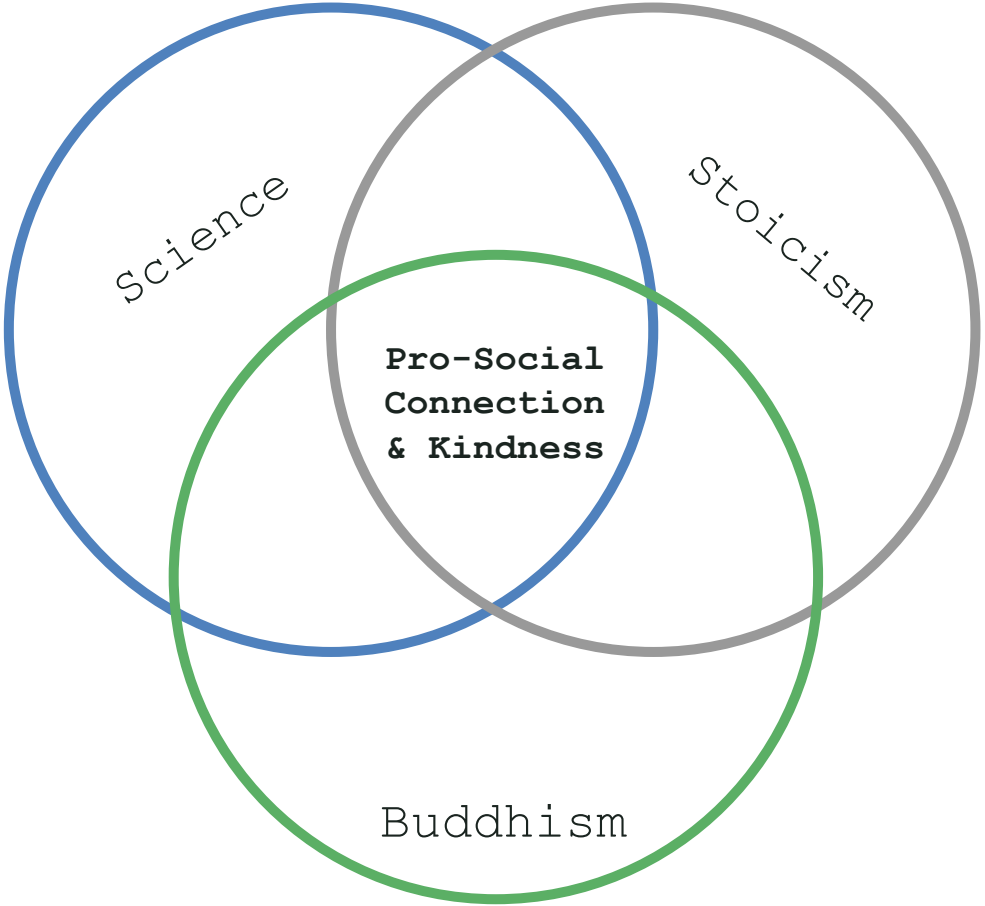
imagining loss to break habituation and reclaim appreciation.



Core Shared Insight: Conscious Appreciation Overcomes Adaptation

You should be in the moment appreciating what you already have
Focus on how you can lose this or on what you have already obtained!

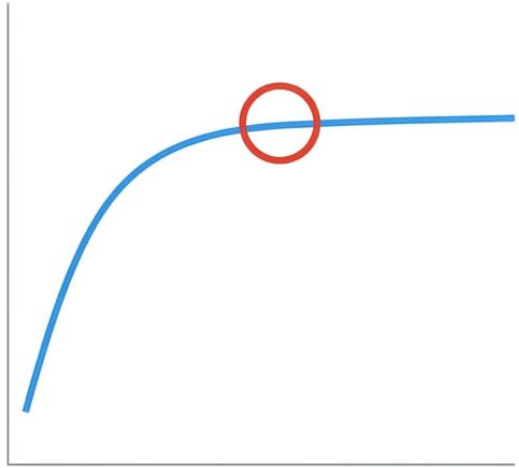
The Grand Intersection of solutions



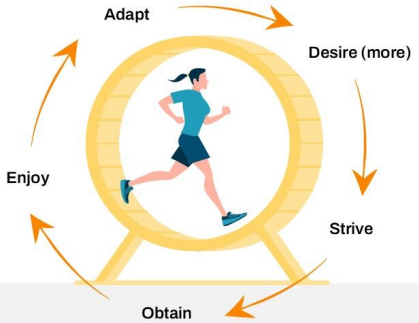
Why? The Human Brain Glitch

The architecture of a good life

- Fact: Brain lies about future joy
- Theory on why: Wired for survival, not happiness
- **Hedonic Treadmill:** Return to baseline dissatisfaction.

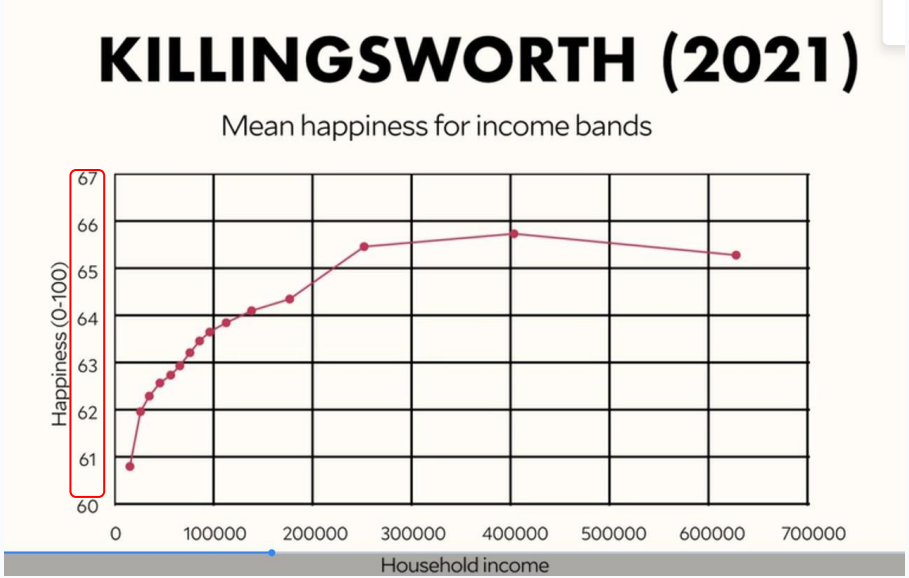






Money 💵💰 & Happiness ✨

Killingsworth et al. (2021, 2023) — Re-analysis of Kahneman & Deaton (2010)



😔 Unhappiest Group (Bottom 15%)

Money reduces suffering, but hits a **strict threshold**. Extra wealth won't fix fundamental unhappiness.

😃 Happiest Group (Top 15%)

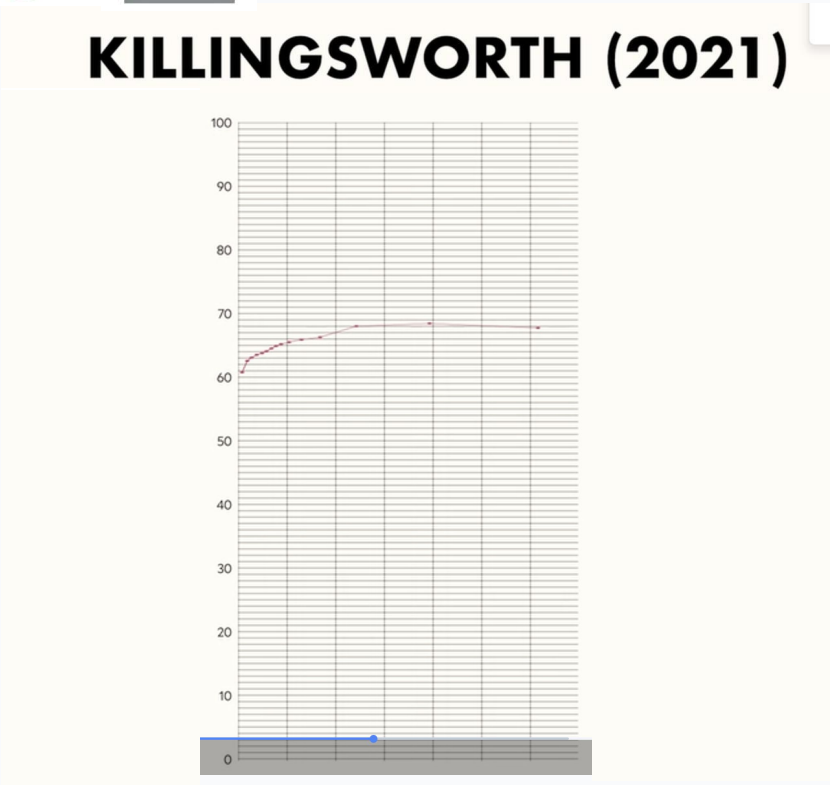
Happiness **steadily accelerates** with income. More wealth continuously amplifies existing joy!

❗ BUT Overall Link is Weak (r = 0.09)

Moving from **$15k ➔ $250k** income only yields a **+5p boost** in happiness !!!

Money 💵💰 & Happiness ✨

Killingsworth et al. (2021, 2023) — Re-analysis of Kahneman & Deaton (2010)



For reference: this is ~Headache level!

What else does NOT make you happy (glitches)

Marriage helps only for 5 years, sorry



🛍️ **Awesome Stuff (owning items, new car/home)**

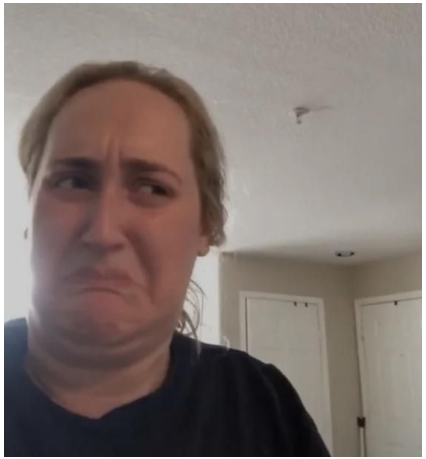
❤️ **True Love (only over time)**

💪 **Perfect Body (weight loss & plastic surgeries)**

😎**Being the coolest on Instagram/LinkedIn etc**

+fan fact: even if you are the coolest you still feel worse

But what else can we do?



THE SCIENCE OF HAPPINESS

Evidence-based takeaways for daily well-being



Avoid Social Comparison

Social media and comparing yourself to others harms mental health.



Experiences Over Things

Experiences make us happier than things.

Helps with social comparisons too

THE SCIENCE OF HAPPINESS

Evidence-based takeaways for daily well-being



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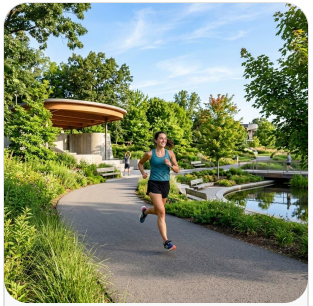
Experiences Over Things

Experiences make us happier than things. Memories are more valuable than purchases.



Sleep

Quality sleep is the foundation of emotional stability.



Exercise

Physical activity reduces stress and boosts endorphin levels.



Meditation

Meditation trains mindfulness and reduces background anxiety.

THE DICHOTOMY OF CONTROL

The Stoic framework for peace of mind and effective action

FULL CONTROL

💭 Thoughts & Values

Action Principle

⚡ **Invest 100% energy here!**

NO CONTROL

🚗 Traffic & Other People's Actions

Action Principle

🧘 **Acceptance & peace**

THE TRICHOTOMY OF CONTROL

The Stoic framework for peace of mind and effective action



FULL CONTROL



💭 Thoughts & Values

Action Principle

⚡ **Invest 100% energy here!**

PARTIAL CONTROL



🏆 Promotions/Games & Health Outcomes

Action Principle

🤝 **Do best & detach from outcome**

NO CONTROL



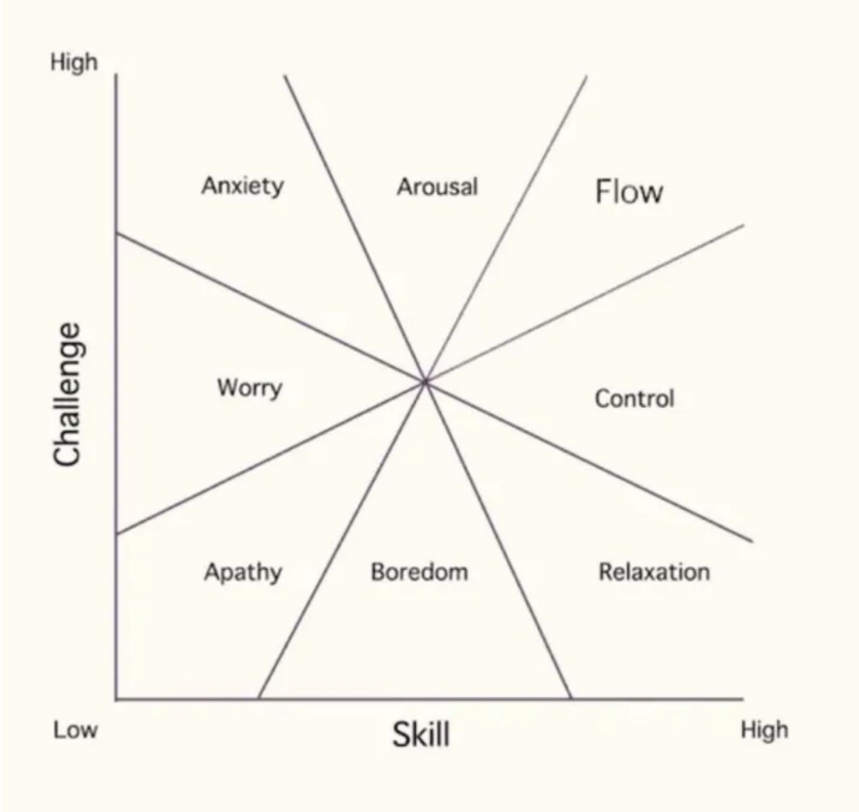
🚗 Traffic & Other People's Actions

Action Principle

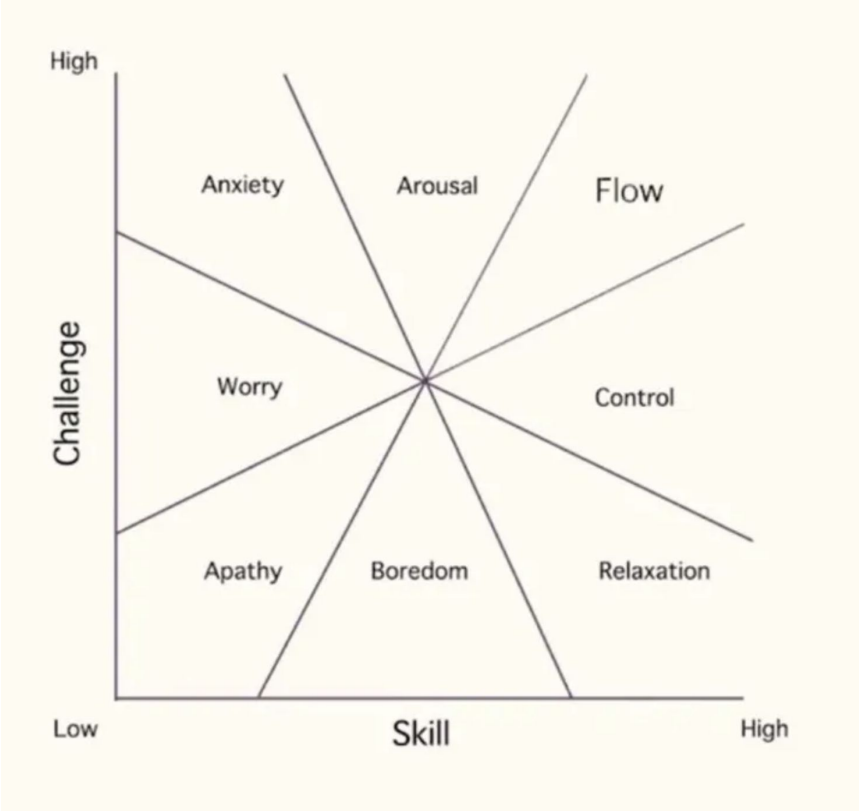
🧘 **Acceptance & peace**

Internalization of Goals ^

The **Formula** for Deep Engagement



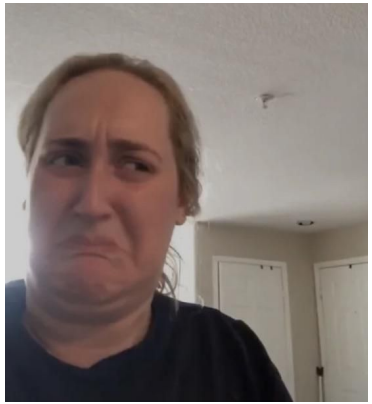
The **Formula** for Deep Engagement



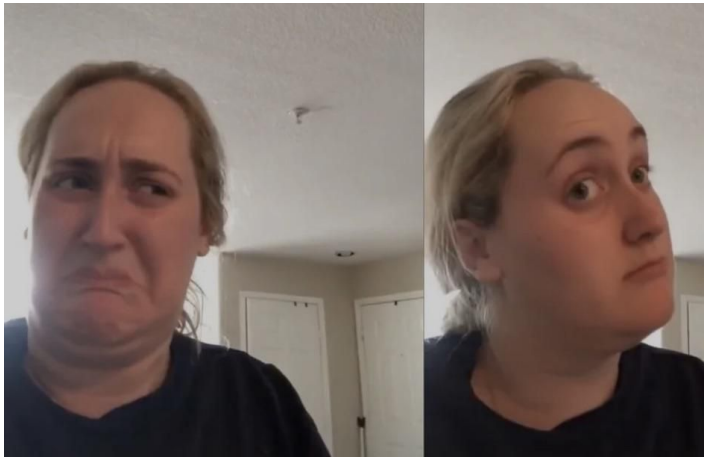
24 CHARACTER STRENGTHS!

- APPRECIATION OF BEAUTY
- BRAVERY
- CITIZENSHIP
- CREATIVITY
- CURIOSITY
- FAIRNESS
- FORGIVENESS AND MERCY
- GRATITUDE
- HOPE
- HUMOR
- INTEGRITY
- JUDGMENT
- KINDNESS
- LEADERSHIP
- LOVE
- LOVE OF LEARNING
- MODESTY AND HUMILITY
- PERSISTENCE
- PERSPECTIVE
- PRUDENCE
- SELF-REGULATION
- SOCIAL INTELLIGENCE
- SPIRITUALITY
- ZEST

Am I happy?



Please rephrase to:
Am I happier than a year before?

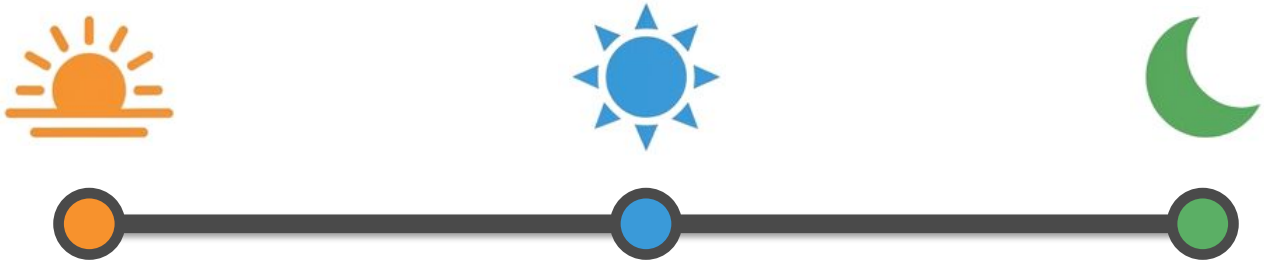


And then follow slides to answer Yes next year*

The Architecture of Control

	Trichotomy of Control	**Negative Visualization**	**Voluntary Discomfort**
Focus	Complete Control (Beliefs, Goals, Actions) vs. Zero Control (Weather, Past, Opinions).	Internalize goals. Play your best, accept the rest.	Peace of mind, regardless of the result.
	Reversing Adaptation (Imagining loss).	Briefly imagine losing what you value.	Increased gratitude and appreciation.
	Building Resilience (Choosing hardship).	Occasionally choose discomfort on purpose.	Mental fortitude for future challenges.

The Daily Blueprint



Sunrise (Stoic)

Define the Trichotomy: Separate what is in your control from what is not.

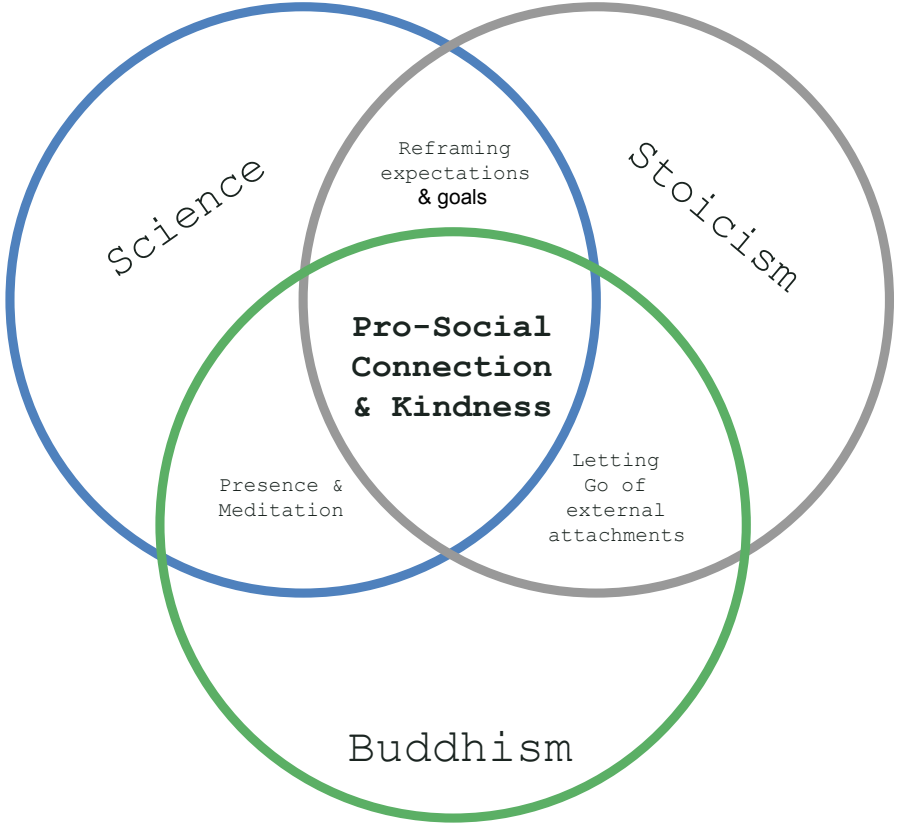
Midday (Science)

Deploy a Signature Strength for “Max Fun”. Initiate one act of pro-social connection.

Moon (Buddhism)

Practice 5 minutes of Mindfulness. Notice your thoughts dissolving.

Questions time



Summary: All Ideas on How to Improve & Be Happier

1. Mindset, Perception & Gratitude

- **Negative Visualization:** Regularly imagine losing what you hold dear to break habituation and reclaim gratitude (Stoic practice). **+ Savoring & Active Gratitude**
- **Avoid Social Comparison:** Limit social media; stop comparing yourself to others on Instagram/LinkedIn, which reliably damages mental health.
- **Reframe Wealth & Consumption:** Define “enough.” Prioritize shared experiences, memories and connection over possessions.
- **Rephrase the Baseline Question:** Shift from 'Am I happy?' to 'Am I happier than a year before?' to focus on growth and personal trajectory.

2. Control & Managing Expectations

- **Trichotomy of Control:** Categorize life into full control, partial control, and no control.
    - **Internalize Goals**: Set effort goals, do your best and loosen demands on external results.
    - **Practice Radically Peaceful Acceptance:** Accept what you cannot control (traffic, other people's actions, external circumstances).

3. Daily Habits & Physical Foundation

- **Quality Sleep & Physical Exercise:** Protect 7+ hours of sleep and 30 minutes of daily movement.
- **Daily Meditation:** Trains mindfulness, calms monkey mind, and reduces baseline background anxiety
- **Buy Experiences Over Material Things:** Experiences foster lasting memories, cultivate connection, and resist hedonic adaptation far better than possessions.

4. Purpose, Deep Engagement & Connection

- **Find Flow:** Pursue activities where high challenge meets your high skills to enter deep focus instead of passive leisure/apathy.
- **Deploy Signature Strengths:** Engage your unique character strengths at work and in hobbies to achieve 'Max Fun' and genuine fulfillment.
- **Pro-Social Connection & Kindness:** Perform acts of kindness and invest in meaningful relationships; works across all cultures and income levels.

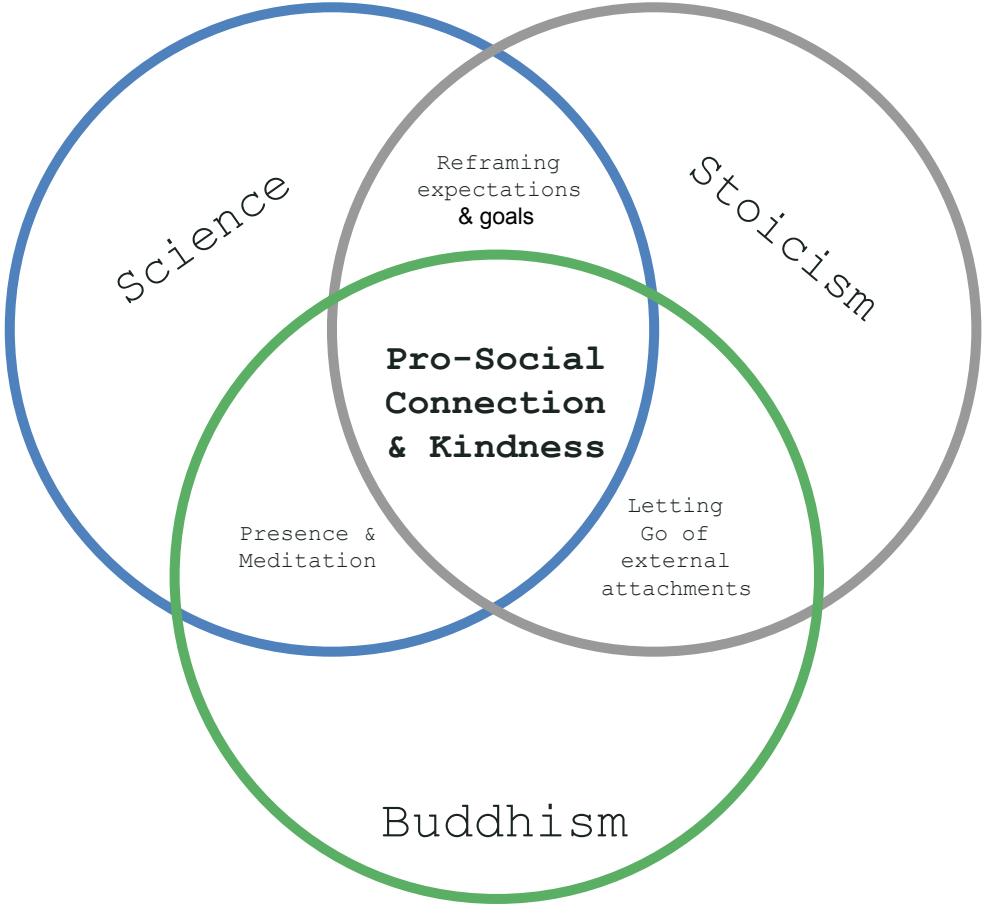
The Grand Intersection of solutions

DUNN ET AL. (2008)



PEOPLE'S PREDICTIONS?

- $$ ON SELF >> $$ ON OTHER
- SPEND $20 >> SPEND $5



The Grand Intersection of solutions

DUNN ET AL. (2008)

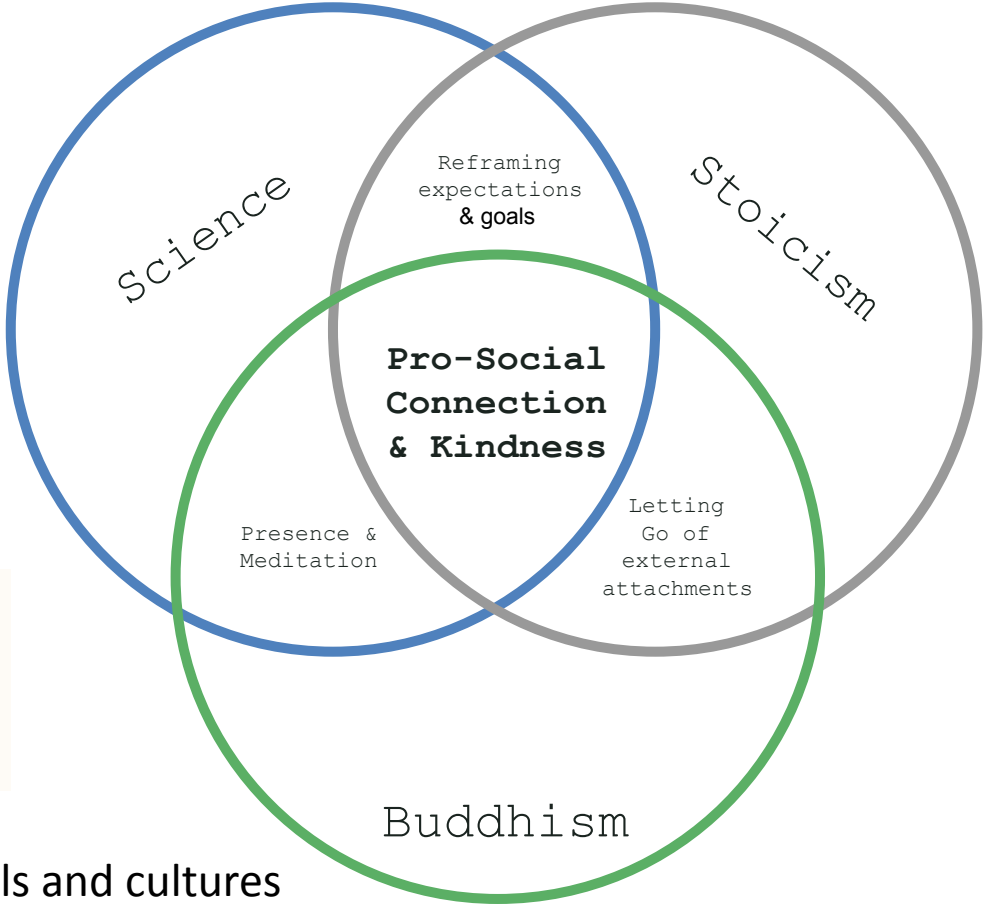


PEOPLE'S PREDICTIONS?

- $$ ON SELF >> $$ ON OTHER
- SPEND $20 >> SPEND $5

WHAT REALLY HAPPENS?

- $$ ON OTHER >> $$ ON SELF
- SPEND $5 = SPEND $20



*This exp. works on multiple income levels and cultures